

3.4 Unit 4 ELLA4 - Comparative Analysis through Independent Study

This unit will extend the principles of integrated literary and linguistic analysis by testing the ability of candidates to:

- use appropriate terminology in their analysis
- make comparisons by sustaining a particular line of thinking in relation to the two chosen texts
- produce accurate, fluent and coherent written work.

Candidates are required to answer one question on two set texts: they have a free choice of question on the two texts that they have chosen to study but each question must be approved by the candidate's tutor. The question should focus on challenging comparative issues. **Candidates must show evidence of a drafting process in their coursework and it is therefore a requirement to submit one draft with their final assessed piece.** They must write between 2,000 and 2,500 words.

A consortium system operates for this specification, in line with the other AQA GCE English Specification A suites, where centres initially submit candidates' questions to consortium advisers for scrutiny, acceptance and moderation. These consortium advisers also act in an advisory capacity to centres throughout the year.

Candidates are required to study at least one poetry text, a genre not available at AS level. Candidates must choose **one text** from List A; they may then choose one other text from List A or one from List B.

The intention behind this constrained choice is to offer texts which have been externally verified for their suitability for this coursework unit. Centres should discourage candidates from writing at length about biographical details of any of the writers. The primary focus of candidates' work must be on literary and linguistic analysis and comparative issues within the texts.

List A (Poetry)

Ariel: Sylvia Plath

The Whitsun Weddings: Philip Larkin

The Wife of Bath's Prologue and Tale: Geoffrey Chaucer

Selected Poems: D.H. Lawrence

Taking off Emily Dickinson's Clothes: Billy Collins

Selected Poems: Robert Frost

Songs of Innocence and of Experience: William Blake

Selected Poems 1965-75: Seamus Heaney

Selected Poems: William Wordsworth

Mean Time: Carol Ann Duffy

Selected Poems: Emily Dickinson

Selected Poems: Elizabeth Jennings

List B (Other Genres)

A Handmaid's Tale: Margaret Atwood

Hamlet: William Shakespeare

As You Like It: William Shakespeare

The Penguin Book of Modern Short Stories: ed.
Malcolm Bradbury

Small Island: Andrea Levy

The Accidental Tourist: Anne Tyler

Waterland: Graham Swift

A Prayer for Owen Meany: John Irving

Dubliners: James Joyce

Hotel World: Ali Smith

Death of a Salesman: Arthur Miller

Translations: Brian Friel

Some additional clarifications

The purpose of this unit is to show an ability to use literary and linguistic terminology for analysis (AO1) and to make comparisons considering context (AO3).

Each AO is weighted equally (30 marks).

The coursework is **not** an opportunity to write broadly on general themes or to relate them to the lives of the poets / writers. Rather, it is a chance to show the skills of close technical analysis in a comparative format. The essay should be concerned with the question of **how / in what ways** writers create their effects in order to focus on a particular theme.

Unless the candidate chooses two poets, comparisons will inevitably need to explain the different demands of the genre used (poetry, drama, short story, novel) but these should be confined to the specific differences of the texts chosen rather than a more generalised approach to genre difference. Similarly, though context may be important in explaining language change or specific historical attitudes, candidates should give a lesser emphasis to these areas than they do to technical analysis.

Typically, a good coursework title will be 'Compare **the ways in which** X and Y write about loneliness / death / the countryside etc.' while an unsuitable title might be 'Is X better than Y?' or 'How typical are X and Y of the periods in which they were writing?'

List A / List B examples

1. *The Whitsun Weddings*: Philip Larkin / *Dubliners*: James Joyce

Compare the ways in which Larkin and Joyce portray family relationships.

2. *Mean Time*: Carol Ann Duffy / *Hotel World*: Ali Smith

Compare the ways in which Duffy and Smith use different narrative points of view.

3. *Taking Off Emily Dickinson's Clothes*: Billy Collins / *The Accidental Tourist*: Anne Tyler

Compare the ways in which Collins and Tyler present ideas about travel.

List A only examples

1. *Selected Poems*: Robert Frost / *Selected Poems*: William Wordsworth

Compare the ways in which Frost and Wordsworth write about friendship.

2. *Taking Off Emily Dickinson's Clothes*: Billy Collins / *Mean Time*: Carol Ann Duffy

Compare the ways in which Collins and Duffy use irony.

3. *Selected Poetry*: D.H. Lawrence / *Selected Poems*: Emily Dickinson

Compare the ways in which Lawrence and Dickinson make use of the natural world.

In the production of their coursework candidates are encouraged to read widely, to include at the end of their essays a bibliography of works read and to make appropriate reference to them, where relevant, in the body of the coursework. However, it must be stressed that a personal response is what is required and an inclusion of critical references is not essential.

Assessment Criteria for Coursework

MARK BAND DESCRIPTORS (AO1)

To be placed in a particular mark band, it is not necessary for a candidate to demonstrate achievement under every point. Internal assessment should therefore assess a candidate's work under the 'best fit' principle.

Band 5 (26-30)

- use of framework(s) enhances and illuminates textual interpretation
- has an overview of the text
- engages closely with the meaning of the texts; patterns analysed
- conceptualised analysis
- fluent, cogent writing

Upper band 4 (23 – 25)

- coherent analysis through the framework(s); some analytical probing of features and patterns
- thoughtful engagement with texts
- interpretation evident through approach taken
- fluent writing

Lower band 4 (20 – 22)

- uses framework(s) to highlight reading
- describes significant features/patterns
- awareness of stylistic and linguistic features
- engages with texts through explanation of features; possibly under-developed in places
- clear and appropriate writing

Upper band 3 (16 – 19)

- uses a suitable framework(s)
- evidence of some range
- sense of patterns may emerge in places; likely to be under-developed
- may use different approaches for literary/linguistic study; able to distinguish between different features fairly accurately but may be unable to comment on effect of features
- clear, but straightforward, expression

Lower band 3 (12 – 15)

- identification through framework(s) shows some of writer's choices within the text
- list-like but sound ideas
- broad comments on effects and stylistic points
- aware different modes need approaching in different ways but may do so in simplistic fashion
- straightforward expression with some errors

Upper band 2 (9 – 11)

- simplistic
- attempts to use framework(s) but likely to be limited
- identifies some points
- limited analysis occurs
- some awareness of the focus of a text
- common sense approach but does not discuss how language works
- underdeveloped writing

Lower band 2 (7 – 8)

- scattergun approach to analysis
- little apparent planning with probably no use of framework(s)
- implicit views of language use
- superficial ideas
- muddled expression with very few relevant ideas

Band 1 (1 – 6)

- little awareness
- possible framework misconceptions
- weak writing
- no apparent direction
- very wayward
- persistent misuse of terms
- inaccuracies abound

MARK BAND DESCRIPTORS (AO3)

To be placed in a particular mark band, it is not necessary for a candidate to demonstrate achievement under every point. Internal assessment should therefore assess a candidate's work under the 'best fit' principle.

Band 5 (26 – 30)

- assimilates and contextualises references with originality
- total overview that may offer observations on wider contexts
- exploratory
- significant similarities and differences are analysed and in an original, personal, or conceptual, manner
- texts effortlessly integrated

Upper band 4 (23 – 25)

- skilful and secure analysis and commentary
- clear sense of context/variation/contextual influences underpins reading
- close focus on texts
- coherently compares and contrasts writer's choices of form, structure, mode, language
- confident comparison

Lower band 4 (20 – 22)

- expresses clearly comparisons and contrasts between two texts
- clear interplay between text and context/sense of contextual variation
- comments clearly on a variety of points/areas
- analysis may be imbalanced; may use anchor text; possible imbalance in text coverage

Upper band 3 (16 – 19)

- context commented on
- points are made but not clearly developed
- analysis may show implicit meanings
- some comment on language use in texts
- imbalance in coverage or only two texts compared

Lower band 3 (12 – 15)

- comparative framework(s) used but may be partial/simplistic
- develops a line of argument underpinned by comment on overall context
- probably list-like in construction
- imbalance in coverage of texts
- lacks evidence in places

Upper band 2 (9 – 11)

- may see how context influences language use
- general awareness of writer's techniques and impact on meaning
- responds to obvious or broad links or comparisons
- sometimes comments on less important links
- may lack detail and evidence

Lower band 2 (7 – 8)

- superficial idea of context
- occasional insight but not sustained
- one area of study noted, others are ignored
- lacks detail and probably little evidence used

Band 1 (1 – 6)

- very little awareness of context
- very limited ideas
- very superficial
- contextual features identified erroneously/misreads
- weak ideas